CULTURE

THE NODAL MINISTRY FOR CURATING the various campaigns under the Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav (AKAM) programme, which Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated in March 2021 as a countdown to the 75th anniversary of Indian Independence, more than 136,000 events have been organised. These include mega events such as Har Ghar Tiranga, Vande Bharatam and Kalanjali. Apart from the Prime Ministers' Museum, inaugurated last year, eight new museums have been setup with financial assistance under the Museum Grant Scheme. The ministry has also taken steps to promote Buddhist culture in other countries, such as funding the construction of the India International Centre for Buddhist Culture and Heritage at Lumbini, Nepal, and organising an exposition of sacred Kapilavastu relics of the Buddha in Mongolia. One of the ministry's achievements has been recovery of artefacts stolen from India—between 1947 and 2014, only 13 stolen artefacts were recovered while 228 such artefacts have been recovered since 2014. Apart from identifying 100 centrally protected monuments and sites as Adarsh Smaraks for providing tourist amenities, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has traced 68 monuments out of the 92 that were reported missing in the performance audit report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India in 2013. However, budgetary allocation for Kala Sanskriti Vikas Yojana, a scheme for promoting art and culture, went down to Rs 21 crore in 2023, from Rs 214 crore in last year's revised estimate. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

₹3,399 CRORE

Outlay for ministry of culture in Union budget

BUT...

- **Budgetary allocation for Kala Sanskriti Vikas Yojana, an umbrella scheme for the promotion of art and culture, goes down from last year's revised estimate**

₹214 CRORE 2022-23

₹210 CRORE 2023-24



TOURISM

TOURISM BEING A STATE SUBJECT, the Union tourism ministry's role is mostly limited to guiding and supporting the industry. The ministry under Swadesh Darshan and PRASHAD schemes provides financial assistance to states for developing tourism-related infrastructure. The high-profile Kashi Vishwanath temple corridor project, which connects the temple with the ghats in Varanasi, ensuring easy movement of pilgrims, was inaugurated in December 2021. To boost tourism as the world recovered from Covid-19, 127,999 free tourist visas were issued between October 6, 2021 and March 31, 2022. The ministry also launched the Dekho Apna Desh initiative to boost domestic tourism. The ministry's digital 'Utsav Portal' aims to showcase all festivals and live *darshans*. Apart from hosting four G20 meetings, the tourism ministry under G. Kishan Reddy is providing support to all G20 events by conducting sensitisation programmes for stakeholders like taxi drivers, hotel staff and guides. Along with the National Digital Tourism Mission to connect the entire sector digitally, the ministry is working on the implementation of the Uniform Tourist Police Scheme to get stakeholders like the Union home ministry, Bureau of Police Research & Development and state governments on the same platform, so that they work in sync to respond to tourism requirements. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

- **Kashi Vishwanath temple corridor project inaugurated in 2021**



- **Digital 'Utsav Portal' to showcase events, fests, live darshans**

BUT...

- **No sign of new tourism policy**